

# Why Does Althusser, in On the Reproduction of Capitalism, Say That "Cooperatives of Purchase, Sale or Production... Belong Wholly and Entirely to the Capitalist Mode of Production"?

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To avoid errors caused by translation, let me first consult the original text<sup>[1]</sup>. Althusser's "appartiennent bel" is the English "belong to" — meaning that cooperatives are a subset of the capitalist mode of production.

qui subsistent.

Quant aux coopératives d'achat de vente ou de production (ces dernières rarissimes) elles **appartiennent bel** et bien au mode de production capitaliste, et ne sont « *l'anticipation* » directe du mode de production

18. Je rappelle un effet de cette « survivance » (= la « classe » des grands propriétaires terriens) ne relève pas du mode de production capitaliste.

On sait que Lénine a d'ailleurs soutenu la thèse (« imaginaire » mais théoriquement intéressante) que dans une formation capitaliste « pure » (sans résidus du mode de production « féodal ») la terre pourrait ou même devrait être... « nationalisée » donc propriété de l'Etat qui la louerait (selon une « rente » purement capitaliste, c'est-à-dire selon une rente différentielle débarrassée de la rente absolue) aux entrepreneurs – fermiers capitalistes.

In my view, this statement of Althusser's has a certain depth, but it is essentially wrong.

First, it does not conform to Marx's own view.

In the Inaugural Address of the International Working Men's Association, Marx discussed the cooperative movement specifically. He first affirmed the significance of the cooperative movement: it

proved that cooperative labour transcending the wage-labour system is feasible.

The political economy of labour achieved an even greater victory over the political economy of property. We mean the cooperative movement, especially the cooperative factories established by the unassisted efforts of a few bold "hands." The value of these great social experiments cannot be overrated. By deed, instead of by argument, they have shown that production on a large scale, and in accord with the behests of modern science, may be carried on without the existence of a class of masters employing a class of hands; that to bear fruit, the means of labour need not be monopolised as a means of dominion over, and of extortion against, the labouring man himself; and that labour, like slave labour and serf labour, is only a transitory and inferior form, destined to disappear before associated labour plying its toil with a willing hand, a ready mind, and a joyous heart.

But at the same time, he pointed out that under capitalist conditions the cooperative movement could hardly grow large; to truly enlarge the cooperatives, there was only one road: to seize state power through revolution.

The experience of the period from 1848 to 1864 has proved beyond doubt that, however excellent in principle and however useful in practice, cooperative labour, if kept within the narrow circle of the casual efforts of private workmen, will never be able to arrest the growth in geometrical progression of monopoly, to free the masses, nor even to perceptibly lighten the burden of their miseries. It is perhaps for this very reason that plausible noblemen, philanthropic middle-class spouters, and even keen political economists, have all at once turned nauseously complimentary to the very cooperative labour system they had vainly tried to nip in the bud by ridiculing it as the utopia of the dreamer, or stigmatising it as the sacrilege of the socialist. To save the labouring masses, cooperative labour ought to be developed to national dimensions, and consequently to be fostered by national means. However, the lords of the land and the lords of capital will always use their political privileges for the defence and perpetuation of their economic monopolies. Not only will they not promote the emancipation of labour, but, on the contrary, they will continue to throw every obstacle in its way... Hence, to conquer political power has become the great duty of the working class.

In summary, for the founders of Marxism, the cooperative as such is in principle non-capitalist; but fighting capitalism through cooperatives cannot succeed.

Lenin expressed the same view in "On Cooperation." He pointed out that many of the absurd ideas of the old participants in the cooperative movement, after the proletariat seized state power, turned out to correspond to reality:

There was a great deal of illusion in the ideals of the old cooperators. They were often laughable because of these illusions. But wherein exactly did their illusions manifest themselves? In that these people did not understand the fundamental significance of the workers' political struggle to overthrow the rule of the exploiters. Now that we have overthrown the rule of the exploiters in our country, much

of what was illusionary — even romantic and vulgar — in the ideals of the old cooperators is becoming unvarnished reality.

Lenin held that in the transition period of the dictatorship of the proletariat — the NEP period — the development of cooperatives equals the development of socialism:

But look: now that state power is in the hands of the working class, now that the power of the exploiters has been overthrown and all the means of production (except that part which is temporarily and conditionally voluntarily leased by the workers' state to the exploiters) are in the hands of the working class, the situation is quite different. Now we have the right to say that for us the development of cooperatives is equivalent to the development of socialism (with the one "small" exception mentioned above)...

In short, at the economic level the cooperative is indeed non-capitalist; it does not "belong wholly and entirely to the capitalist mode of production." The backwardness of the cooperative movement lies in the political sphere, not the economic.

Second, analysed by the basic principles of historical materialism and Marxist economics, the cooperative is also non-capitalist.

The cooperative under capitalist conditions still produces for the market — commodity production — but it cannot be said to "belong wholly and entirely to the capitalist mode of production." The capitalist mode of production is commodity production, but the converse does not hold: commodity production is not capitalist production.

Marx held that wage labour is the foundation of capitalist society:

Wage labour is the existing bourgeois organised labour. Without wage labour there would be no capital, no bourgeoisie, no bourgeois society. — Marx, *The Class Struggles in France, 1848 to 1850*

And the wage form of the value of labour power is the root source of all the mystification of the capitalist mode of production:

Hence one can understand the decisive importance of the transformation of the value and price of labour power into the form of wages, i.e. into the value and price of labour itself. This phenomenal form, which makes the actual relation invisible, and indeed shows its direct opposite, forms the basis of all the juridical notions of both the worker and the capitalist, of all the mystifications of the capitalist mode of production, of all its illusions about freedom, and of all the apologetic shifts of the vulgar economists. — Marx, *Capital*

But capitalist society has, besides the mysterious form of wages, another form: commodity fetishism. The wage form only conceals the core contradiction of wage labour; it does not conceal the widely

existing contradiction between commodity value and use value in the market economy. Marx's classic formulation runs:

The commodity-form, and the value-relation of the products of labour within which it appears, has absolutely no connection with the physical nature of the commodity and the material [dinglich] relations arising out of this. It is nothing but the definite social relation between men themselves which assumes here, for them, the fantastic form of a relation between things. In order, therefore, to find an analogy, we must have recourse to the mist-enveloped regions of the religious world. In that world, the productions of the human brain appear as independent beings endowed with life, and entering into relation both with one another and the human race. So it is in the world of commodities with the products of men's hands. This I call fetishism which attaches itself to the products of labour, so soon as they are produced as commodities, and which is therefore inseparable from the production of commodities.

That is to say, even if all enterprises were converted into cooperatives, they would still each carry on commodity production as "private" producers, and commodity fetishism would still exist, the mystery of the commodity would still exist. But this is not a peculiarity of capitalist production; small commodity production has this feature too — it is only that commodity production attains absolute dominance only under capitalist conditions.

Althusser therefore committed a logical error:

He thought that, given the known premises:

- capitalist production is commodity production
- under capitalist conditions, commodity production attains dominance
- cooperative production is commodity production

one may conclude: cooperative production is capitalist production.

Strictly speaking, one can only conclude: under commodity production, the capitalist mode of production is the fittest mode, and all other modes of production can hardly compete stably with it in the long run. Hence the cooperative, though not a capitalist mode of production, cannot outcompete the capitalist mode of production under commodity production. The cooperative is non-capitalist, but fundamentally it is not anti-capitalist; the capitalists have no fear of cooperatives.

So we cannot say that the cooperative "belongs to" the capitalist mode of production; but we can say that in capitalist society the cooperative is "subordinate to" the capitalist mode of production (subordonné), just as small production is "subordinate to" the capitalist mode of production. "Belonging to" expresses a relation of inclusion; "subordinate to" expresses a relation of power.

Perhaps Althusser himself meant what I say — merely that the cooperative movement is of no great use — but failed to express it clearly in writing. We, as his successors, should still get the question straight.

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## Notes

[1] Althusser, Sur la reproduction (P.U.F., 1995), PDF text: <https://datao.eklablog.com/ae-editions/perso/bibliotheque%20-%20pdf/althusser%20-%20sur%20la%20reproduction%20-p.u.f.1995-.pdf>  
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